

6

SESSION

Dec 10 & 11. This session can use both days: demos on the first, critique and the Playbook on the second.

Build Something, and the Critic in the Room

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GOAL

Each participant ships one small artifact that uses what the group learned, demos it, and gets critiqued, with the model used as a reviewer rather than an author: steelman the opposing view, find the weakest claim, name what would change the conclusion. The group finalizes the Playbook.

WHY

Ten weeks of technique are worth little without a made thing. The demos also give you evidence of what the group produced, useful for whoever asks whether it was worth running. And RAND has a peer-review culture: the model is a tireless, tactless first reviewer, and using it this way keeps the words yours.

READY-MADE MATERIALS

Use these when nobody has their own. Everything here is public or was written for this course.

Sample paragraph for the four moves

Written for this course, deliberately hedged and contestable.

Export controls on advanced chips will likely slow China's frontier AI development for several years. Chinese labs currently depend on Nvidia hardware for large training runs, and domestic alternatives appear to lag by at least a generation. Although smuggling and cloud access may blunt the effect somewhat, it seems unlikely that these channels can substitute at scale. The controls therefore probably buy the United States meaningful lead time, which policymakers should use to build governance capacity. Some analysts argue the controls accelerate Chinese self-sufficiency, but this concern may be overstated given the difficulty of replicating the semiconductor supply chain.

Reviewer to name

Review this as a RAND quality assurance reviewer would, then as a skeptical House Appropriations staffer would. Quote the sentence you are criticizing each time.

Default build for anyone who arrives empty-handed

The Session 5 skill doc plus the Session 3 script, turned into a repeatable workflow on the SIPRI data: load, count, chart, one paragraph of findings with page cites. Small enough to finish, real enough to critique.

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MIN

COLD OPEN

Skip; the session is the demo.

65

MIN

CORE

1 The four moves 10

Demo on the sample paragraph: (a) Argue the opposite thesis as persuasively as you can. (b) Identify the three weakest claims and why a hostile reviewer would attack each. (c) What evidence would change this conclusion? (d) Rewrite this as the strongest version of the argument I am not making. Show how "be brutal" produces performed brutality and "what would a reviewer who wanted to reject this say" produces substance.

2 Ground rules 5

Each demo: what problem, what you built, what the model did vs. what you did, what failed, three minutes. Then two minutes of critique: the demo's output goes through one of the four moves, live, and the builder says whether the critique is right and why.

3 Demos 40

Facilitator keeps time hard. Rule: nobody accepts a suggestion without being able to say why it's right.

4 Playbook finalization 10

Walk the Playbook as a group. Delete what didn't hold up. Tighten the failure checklist and the tiering guide. Decide who owns it going forward.

15

MIN

DEBRIEF

Round the room: one thing you do differently now than in September. One thing you still don't trust. Close on the second list; it's the more honest one.

HOMEWORK

None. Or: teach one of these sessions to someone else. Pick the January topic.

60

MIN CUT

FOR 60 MINUTES

Three-minute demos, one-minute critique, no Playbook walk (do it async). **Over two days:** demos on day one; critique round, editing passes from the handout, and the Playbook walk on day two.

FACILITATOR
WATCH-OUTS

- Demos run long. Share a timer on screen. Be the person who cuts off the demo, gently, every time.
 - Sycophancy is the enemy. If the model praises the build, the prompt was wrong.
 - Someone will find the model's critique wrong. Great: articulating why sharpens the argument anyway.
 - The temptation is to end on triumph. End on the "still don't trust" list. It's what they'll remember.
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